



# Hezlett Primary School

## Attendance Policy

Oct 2023

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May 2024

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## ATTENDANCE POLICY

Hezlett Primary School is committed to providing a full and efficient education to all pupils. We embrace the concept of equal opportunities for all. We will endeavour to provide an environment where all pupils feel valued and welcome.

For a child to reach their full educational achievement a high level of school attendance is essential. We will consistently work towards a goal of 100% attendance for all children. Every opportunity will be used to convey to pupils and their parents or carers the importance of regular and punctual attendance.

School attendance is subject to various Education laws and this school attendance policy is written to reflect these laws and the guidance produced by the Department of Education.

### School Procedures

Any child who is absent from school at the morning or afternoon registration period must have their absence recorded as being authorised, unauthorised or as an approved educational activity [attendance out of school]. The school uses Attendance Manager by SIMS to collect, store and monitor all aspects of pupil attendance. If there is no known reason for the absence at registration, then the absence must be recorded in the first instance as unauthorised.

### Lateness

Morning registration will take place at the start of school at 9.00 am. The registers will remain open for 15 minutes. Any pupil arriving after this time will be marked as having an unauthorised absence unless there is an acceptable explanation i.e. school transport was delayed. In cases for example, where the absence at registration was for attending an early morning medical appointment, the appropriate authorized absence code will be entered.

Pupils arriving after the start of school but before the end of the registration period will be treated for statistical purposes, as present, but will be coded as late before registers close. Repeated lateness will be discussed with parents and if no improvement is forthcoming, then the pattern will be reported to the EWO.

If children have to miss school for illness or any other reason, then parents must send a note of explanation, email the school or ring the office. Parents should try to arrange doctor or dentist's appointments for outside school hours whenever possible. If you require your child out of school early, a note should be sent to the class teacher. Children are encouraged to play outside at break and lunch times,

except in bad weather. If your child has an injury which means that it is not advisable for them to play outdoors, then the teacher should be notified in writing.

## ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

### Responsibilities of Parents

Parents are responsible for ensuring their children attend school regularly and punctually. The school will work in close collaboration with the parent to resolve any attendance issues.

- To ensure that their child attends school regularly and punctually
- To inform the school as soon as possible, on the first day of their child's absence
- To provide a written explanation for any absences on the child's return to school
- To avoid taking holidays during term time
- To work alongside the school to support pupil attendance.

### Responsibilities of school:

- To ensure its registration system is accurate and consistently used by staff.
- To analyse data regularly and identify the actions that need to be taken
- To follow up unexplained absences
- To promote good attendance and punctuality
- To work in partnership with families and the Education Welfare Service
- To set and monitor progress towards annual targets for attendance
- To evaluate the effectiveness of the Attendance Policy

### Responsibilities of the Educational Welfare Service:

- To monitor registers regularly
- To identify pupils/families with attendance difficulties
- To agree time-limited action which needs to be taken by the school or EWO

· Provide advice and work in partnership with school and parents

### Monitoring Attendance

- Attendance is monitored regularly by the principal
- Teachers should inform the principal if they notice patterns of absence
- Attendance data will be discussed with the EWO as and when required
- An annual attendance target will be set and reviewed each year
- The principal will report to the governors on pupil attendance
- Individual pupil attendance will be reported to parents at the end of the school year.

### First Day Absence

The child will be marked absent according to the codes laid out in Appendix 1.

### Continuing Absence

If there is no contact from parent, or explanation for the absence, after the third day, the school will attempt to contact the parent by telephone, or e-mail or letter.

### Ten Day's Absence

Any pupil who is absent without an explanation for 10 consecutive days will be notified to the Education Welfare Office. (E.W.O.)

### Frequent Absence

In cases where a pupil begins to develop a pattern of absences, the school will try to resolve the problem with the parent/s. Initially the class teacher will speak with the parent. If this is unsuccessful, the principal will speak with the parent when the % attendance falls to below 90%. If this too is unsuccessful, the school will send parents a letter, informing them that they are seeking advice from the school's Education Welfare Officer (E.W.O.) Elvin Cochrane. This will happen if the child's attendance falls to below 85%. For example, 90% is 1 day of absence each fortnight.

## A Welcome Back

It is important that on return from an absence that all pupils are made to feel welcome. This should include ensuring that the pupil is helped to catch up on missed work and brought up to date on any information that has been passed to the other pupils.

## Promoting attendance

The school will use opportunities as they arise to remind parents/carers, that it is their responsibility to ensure that their children receive their education.

## Holidays in term time

Holidays during term time are to be discouraged. Parents will be reminded of the effect that absence can have on a pupil's potential achievement.

To be reviewed in October 2026

## Absence Codes: Guidance for Schools

### CODE DESCRIPTION MEANING

/ Present (AM) Present

\ Present (PM) Present

A Artistic Endeavour Authorised Absence

B Bereavement Authorised Absence

C Suspended Unauthorised absence

D No reason provided for absence Approved Education Activity

F Family holiday (agreed) Authorised absence

G Family holiday (NOT agreed or days in excess of agreement) Unauthorised Absence

H Other Absence Unauthorised Absence

I Illness (NOT medical or dental etc. appointments) Authorised Absence

L Late (before registers closed) Present

M Medical/Dental appointments Authorised Absence

N No reason yet provided for absence Unauthorised Absence

O Other Exceptional Circumstances Authorised Absence

P Approved sporting activity Approved Education Activity

R Religious observance Authorised Absence

S Study leave Approved Educational Activity

U Late (after registers closed) Unauthorised absence

V Educational visit or trip Approved Education Activity

W Work experience Approved Education Activity

X Only Staff Should Attend Attendance not required

Y Exceptional closure Attendance not required

\* Pupil not yet on roll Attendance not required

# Holiday For All Attendance not required

! No Attendance Required Attendance not required

1 Alternative Education Provision (organised by the ELB) Approved Education Activity

2 Home/hospital tuition (organised by the ELB) Approved Education Activity

3 Elective Home Education Approved Education Activity

4 Pupil Referral Unit Approved Education Activity

5 Another mainstream school (under Entitlement framework – EF) Approved Education Activity

6 Training organisation (under EF) Approved Education Activity

7 FE College (under EF) Approved Education Activity

8 Intensive Support Learning Unit Approved Education Activity

9 CAMHS Approved Education Activity



## **~~Roadway Drainage Structure Exemption from Stream Buffer Variance Requirements~~**

~~To ensure that staff throughout the Georgia Environmental Protection Division (EPD), the Georgia Department of Transportation (GDOT), and other interested and affected parties have a consistent understanding of the requirements for buffer variances where there is a stream crossing and related roadway drainage structure, this document describes the related legal authority and includes guidance for how to apply the exemption for the construction of roadway drainage structures.~~

~~This document provides clarification and guidance related to the information provided in the September 20, 2010, memorandum from Jim Ussery entitled “Buffer Variance Issues” and the related June 8, 2006, memorandum from Bert Langley. Since those memoranda were issued, the Georgia Erosion and Sedimentation Control Act, O.C.G.A. § 12-7-1 *et seq.* (GESA) and related regulations have been amended. EPD also has had over a decade of experience working with that guidance. As a result, EPD has identified areas where clarification and refinement will lead to better and more straightforward application of the related requirements, and greater consistency with current legal authority. Further, although those prior memoranda were directed exclusively to GDOT, this issue affects all entities who may engage in construction in a stream buffer. Replacing those earlier documents with one of more general applicability is thus more appropriate.~~

## Legal Background

### GESA

~~Under GESA, buffer variances are required for all land disturbing activity taking place within the defined buffers of waters of the state or delineated coastal marshlands, unless one of the specific enumerated exemptions apply. See O.C.G.A. §§ 12-7-6(b)(15)-(17), (b.1), 12-7-17. One such exemption is for construction projects carried out by or financed by GDOT. *Id.* at 12-7-17(9). Further, Georgia regulations provide that a stream buffer variance is not required for any entity for land disturbing activity in the buffer “where roadway drainage structures must be constructed.” Ga. Comp. R. and Regs. 391-3-7-.05(1)(c).<sup>1</sup> A “roadway drainage structure” is defined in GESA as “a device, such as a bridge, culvert, or ditch, composed of a virtually nonerodable material such as concrete, steel, plastic, or other such material that conveys water under a roadway by intercepting the flow on one side of a traveled way consisting of one or more defined lanes, with or without shoulder areas, and carrying water to a release point on the other side.” O.C.G.A. § 12-7-3(13).~~

### GWQCA

~~Land disturbing activity may also be subject to requirements under the Georgia Water Quality Control Act, O.C.G.A. § 12-5-20 *et seq.* (GWQCA) and federal Clean Water Act. See also *id.* at 12-7-18 (GESA does not authorize any violations of the GWQCA); § 12-7-6(a)(3) (reference to state general permits under GWQCA). The GWQCA and federal Clean Water Act require that land disturbing activity meeting certain parameters be authorized pursuant to a construction stormwater NPDES permit. *E.g.*, § 12-5-30(f). Most typically, road construction work proceeds under GAR100002, the NPDES Construction General Stormwater Permit for Infrastructure Construction Projects (Permit).~~

### Construction Stormwater General Permit

~~The construction general stormwater Permit mandates that a buffer variance be obtained from EPD for any work in stream buffers; in the 2018 version of the Permit this language appears in Section IV(i)-(ii).<sup>2</sup> This is consistent with GESA, which requires that GDOT (and its contractors) create and maintain compliance with an Erosion, Sedimentation and Pollution Control Plan (Plan), including best management practices to protect water quality, and which specifically states that compliance with the GWQCA is required. *Id.* at §§ 12-7-7.1(e), (g), 12-7-18.~~

~~Any permittee, including GDOT, proceeding under the Permit must obtain stream buffer variances for all land disturbing activity carried out under the Permit that disturbs the 25-foot or 50-foot stream buffer. See 2018 Permit at Section IV. The Permit, however, specifically exempts from this variance requirement land disturbance in the stream buffer “where a roadway drainage structure must be constructed.” Permit Section IV(i)-(ii). Because the Permit also references the requirements of GESA, the definition of “roadway drainage structure” in that statute applies. See *id.*; see also O.C.G.A. § 12-7-3(13). Further,~~

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<sup>1</sup> There is a similar exemption for construction or maintenance of a drainage structure or roadway drainage structure in a coastal marshland buffer. Ga. Comp. R. and Regs. 391-3-7-.11(1)(e). Because the roadway approach and crossing issues for those buffers are different than for stream buffers, that exemption is not addressed in this document.

<sup>2</sup> Likewise, there is an exemption for construction or maintenance of drainage structures or roadway drainage structures in coastal marshland buffers. Permit at Section IV(iii).

in the definition of “roadway projects,” “traveled ways” are described to include roads, sidewalks, paths, trails, and airport runways and taxiways. Permit I.B.36.

### **Applying the Roadway Drainage Structure Exemption**

Applying this legal framework to individual projects can be challenging. Depending on the stream channel, location of the road project, type of drainage structure, and other topographical and physical features, the form and structure of the roadway and associated drainage structures will vary. This may mean that some land disturbing activity is exempt from the buffer variance requirement because it is part of roadway drainage structure construction, while other associated activity is not exempt. This document sets out guidance for determining the typical amount of area necessary to construct a roadway drainage structure and to facilitate the determination of what type of land disturbing activities are exempt from state mandated buffer requirements.

Any stream crossing structure, i.e., a bridge, necessarily will involve some roadway drainage structure construction within the buffer and for some amount of the road as it approaches the stream. In addition, to construct the roadway drainage structure may trigger the need to relocate existing structures or utilities. That work—the roadway drainage structure construction and the land disturbing activities required to remove existing utilities or structures to accommodate a roadway drainage structure—is exempt from the stream buffer variance requirement. Other aspects of constructing or expanding a road or stream crossing structure—such as constructing the new, relocated utility trench—are unrelated to the construction of the roadway drainage structure and, thus, are *not* exempt from the buffer variance requirement. Ga. Comp. R. and Regs. 391-3-7-.05(1)(c); 391-3-7-.11(1)(e).

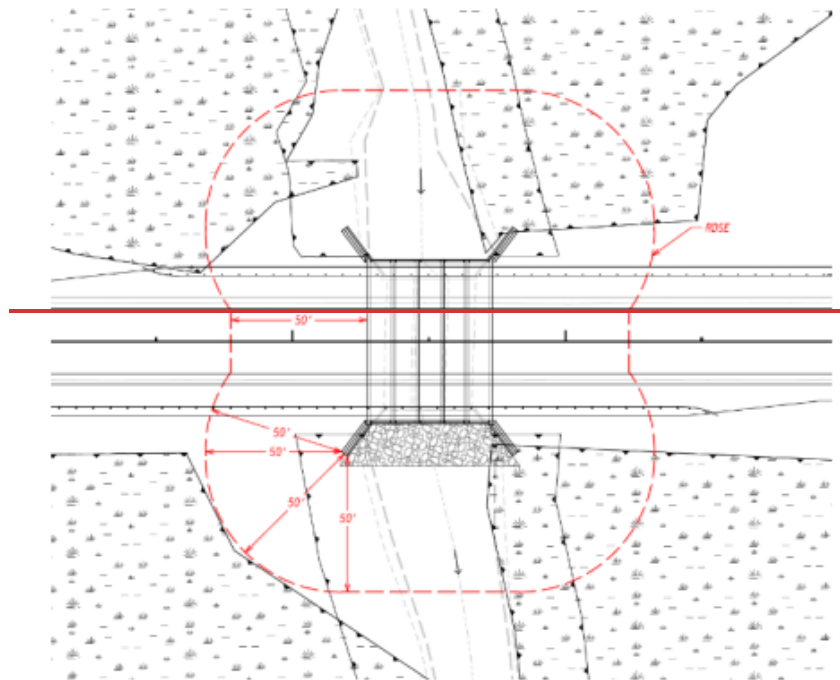
Based on EPD’s experience in reviewing and assessing stream buffer variance applications and road construction projects, along with input from stakeholders, EPD has assessed the area of disturbance typically necessary to construct the drainage structures. For a bridge, that area typically includes soil compaction along the traveled way in a radius of approximately one hundred (100) feet from the bridge or, as appropriate, a box of one hundred (100) by one hundred (100) feet in dimension, as measured from the roadway drainage structure. For a culvert, soil compaction along the traveled way in a radius of approximately fifty (50) feet from the culvert, or, as appropriate, a box of fifty (50) by fifty (50) feet in dimension, as measured from the roadway drainage structure. Whether the radius or box structure is most appropriate will depend on the nature of the roadway drainage structure (e.g., does the culvert have angled wing walls?) and topography.

That compaction work is exempt from the variance requirement as part of construction of a roadway drainage structure; that is, a radius or box of either 100 feet or 50 feet of compaction as measured from the bridge or culvert structure does not require a buffer variance. Obviously, land disturbance should be kept to a minimum and only the areas necessary for roadway drainage structure construction activities should be disturbed. In addition, other proposed buffer disturbance within that radius or box that is not directly necessary for the construction of the roadway drainage structure itself does require a buffer variance, even if the disturbance may be associated with construction of the bridge or culvert.

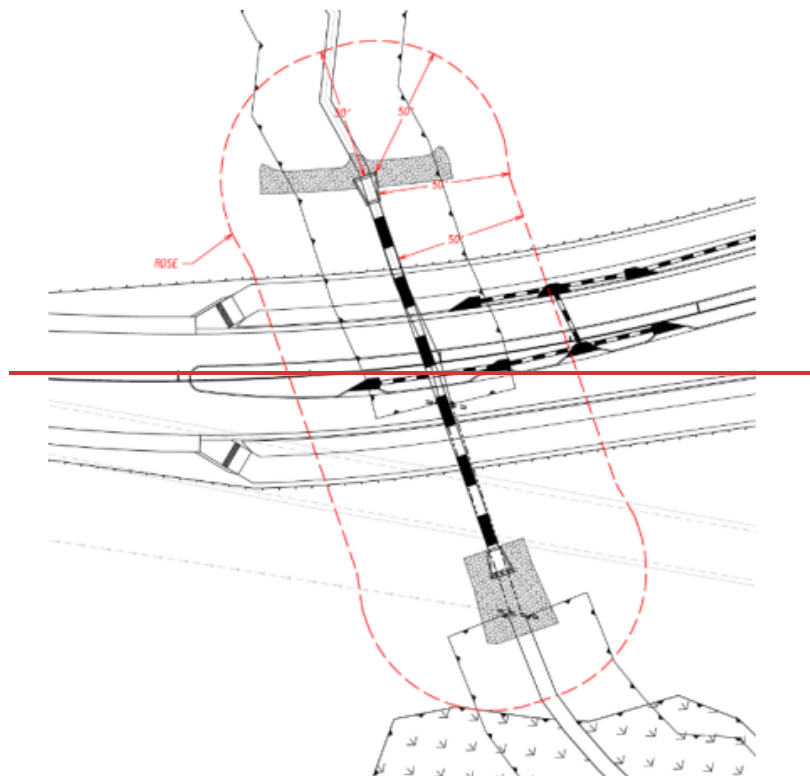
In the below examples, soil compaction and utility/roadway structure removal necessitated by roadway drainage structure construction itself that occurs within the areas outlined in red is exempt from the requirement to obtain a buffer variance. All *other* land

~~disturbing activity in the stream buffer, including activity within the areas outlined in red, will require a buffer variance.~~

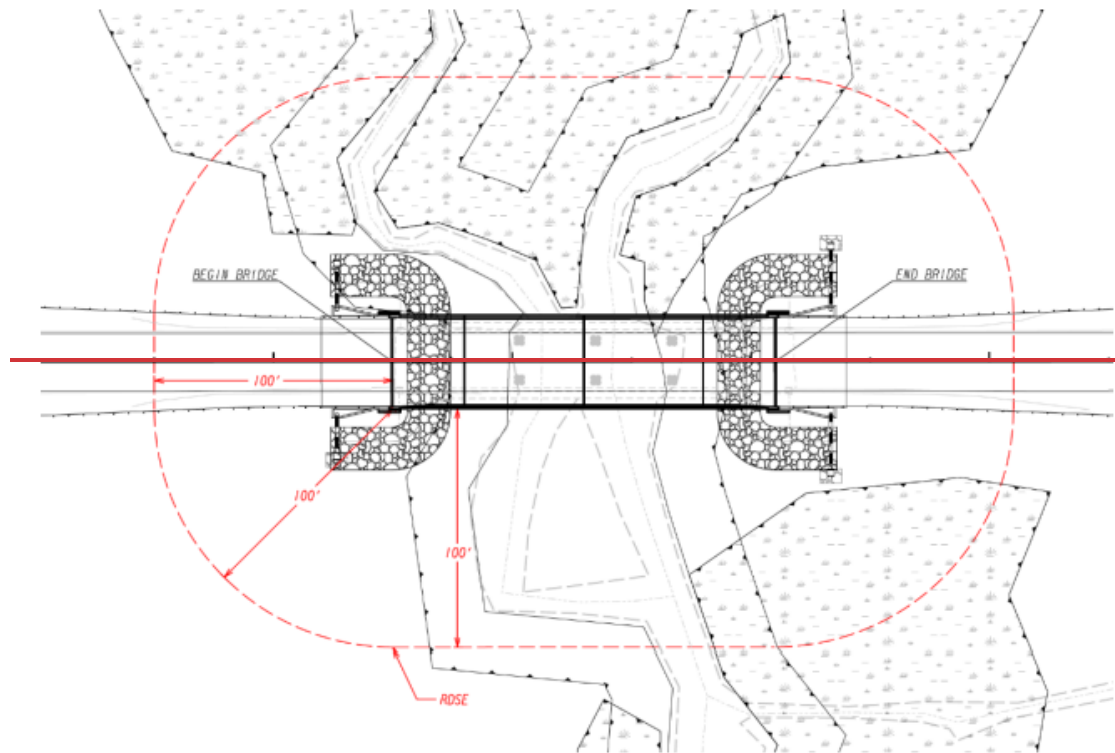
### Example 1. Box Culvert RDSE Area



### Example 2. Pipe Culvert RDSE Area



### Example 3. Bridge RDSE Area



For projects with an associated buffer variance request, the boundaries of the exemption area(s) should be accurately delineated on the required Plan sheets. The work to be carried out within those boundaries should also be described on the Plan, including whether the work is or is not related to the construction of a roadway drainage structure or to remove existing utilities or structures to accommodate a drainage structure.

There may be situations where construction of a roadway drainage structure may require disturbance that exceeds the 100 feet for a bridge or 50 feet for a culvert describe above. For those situations, before conducting any land disturbing activity the entity seeking to work under the roadway drainage structure exemption must first submit in writing to EPD's Nonpoint Source Program, Watershed Protection Branch, documentation showing the exact additional area proposed to be disturbed, a description of the work to be performed in that area, and their rationale for why the exemption applies. EPD will review that submission.

If EPD determines that the additional disturbance is necessary, it will respond in writing with a description of the exact amount of area and type of work in that area that EPD has determined is exempt from the buffer variance requirement. EPD will also provide a copy of that letter to the appropriate District Office. No land disturbing activity should be conducted until this letter from the EPD Nonpoint Source Program has been received.